



**LETHAL BLOW:** Benazir (left) minutes before her death; the scene of the Rawalpindi blast

## Benazir Bhutto

A Heroic Journey

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Born to Nusrat and Zulfikar Ali Bhutto in Karachi on June 21. Studied at Harvard and Oxford.

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Father hanged by Zia-ul-Haq after a military coup. Benazir kept in solitary confinement.

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Became first woman prime minister of an Islamic nation. Held peace summit with Rajiv Gandhi. Was deposed in 1990.

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Became prime minister again. Brother Murtaza Bhutto killed in 1996. Dismissed on corruption charges in 1996.

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Went to Dubai on a self imposed exile. Found guilty of corruption in 1999 along with husband Asif Ali Zardari.

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Returned in October and survived a suicide bombing in Karachi. Was killed on December 27 at Rawalpindi.

■ By Muhammad Najeeb in Rawalpindi and Hasan Zaidi in Karachi

*"I didn't choose this life. It chose me."*

—Benazir Bhutto in *Daughter of the East*

In the half-light of winter dusk, in the space of a few moments, the life of a nation struggling for equilibrium was forever transformed. The assassination of Benazir Bhutto had been anticipated given the churning within Pakistan. It had been predicted, given Bhutto's willingness to deal with a military dictator who had only grudgingly given up his uniform. It had even been forewarned, as a suicide bomber blew himself up within 100 metre of her armoured car, killing 140 on October 18, the day Bhutto returned from an exile that lasted nearly eight years. But when both bullet and bomb cut short the life of the woman who could have been prime minister again, the seismic aftershocks ripped through not just her traumatised nation, but the entire world. With trouble raging in its western regions, reports of widespread Talibanisation on its frontiers and unrest in its army, Pakistan was headed for the first election in six years that would feature the country's two main political leaders—Bhutto and Nawaz Sharif. A state of emergency had just been lifted and it appeared to be